



◀ THE YEAR OF AFRICA

1960 marked a turning point for the continent, as it was the year when 17 African nations, including Cameroon, Ivory Coast, Senegal, Nigeria, Somalia, and others, gained independence from their colonizers. European rulers, such as King Baudouin of Belgium (right), were obliged to hand over power to African rulers.

African independence

In the mid-20th century, following the end of World War II, African countries successfully gained their freedom from the European countries that had colonized them. Some African independence movements were born from armed struggle, but many involved peaceful handovers when it became clear that foreign rule had to end.

In the 19th century, seven European nations—Britain, France, Spain, Italy, Portugal, Belgium, and Germany—established control over almost the entire African continent (see pp.158–159).

After World War II, the demand for independence from colonial rule in many African nations grew stronger. In various countries, people rose up in rebellion against their European colonizers. In 1952, a group of Kenyan

freedom fighters known as the Mau Mau revolted against the British authorities. Between 1954 and 1962, Algerian rebels waged a war against French forces. When it became clear that the European countries would not be able to maintain imperial rule for much longer, the colonies were granted the right to self rule. More than 20 new nations were formed between 1956 and 1960, as former colonies gained independence.



◀ FREEDOM ACROSS AFRICA

A total of 46 African nations gained independence between 1957 and 1980. The first was Ghana and the last was Zimbabwe. The fight for freedom was a shared struggle for all Africans. Today, many people across the continent celebrate the date of their nation's independence with music, dance, and fireworks.

NEW NATIONS

1952

In a revolution that sought to end the British occupation of Egypt, King Farouk is toppled by army officers. The Republic of Egypt is born.

1957

Ghana, under British rule, becomes the first sub-Saharan African nation to achieve independence. The leader of the freedom movement, Kwame Nkrumah, becomes the first Prime Minister of Ghana.



1964-1968

More nations gain independence from colonial rulers including Malawi, Zambia, Botswana, Mauritius, Swaziland, and Equatorial Guinea.

1980

After a 15-year-long civil war, the British colony of Rhodesia gains independence and forms the nation of Zimbabwe.